



Blogging Grandma dies

Spain's most celebrated blogger, a 97 year old by the name of Maria Amelia Lopez, who started blogging when she was 95 passed away on the 22 of May. Her blog can be read at amis95.blogspot.com

Firefox OS

Plans are afoot to implement more thoroughly what Google Chrome has started – to create an entire operating system built on a browser

Languages: languages are simple extensions which map different sentences to their equivalents in other languages, allowing your web site to be accessible to more people.

Templates: these allow you to completely change the look of the site. Templates are the pieces of code which finally decide what kind of content should go where, so more than just the looks, they decide how a person interacts with the site.

Drupal

Another popular CMS which competes with Joomla, Drupal differs quite a bit. Architecturally, it is more of a framework for building CMS applications than a CMS itself. However, even out-of-the-box, it is sufficient to create a web site.

Drupal has a layers-based approach – data, modules, blocks, users, and templates, each extendable. It is a collection of interconnected features which can be put together depending on your requirement. It supports the addition of modules, which could do anything from display a simple text editor for entering content, to add a complex podcasting platform.

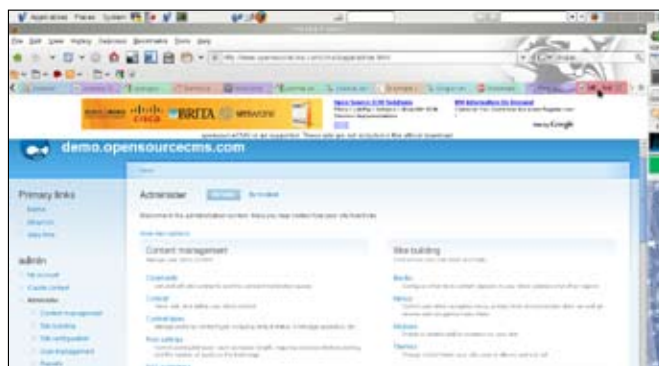
Drupal is often criticised for its weaker support for visual customisation with themes (equivalent to templates in Joomla). A lot of work is being put into Drupal to make it even more powerful in this respect.

Taxonomy: instead of having a rigid section-category system, Drupal allows you to create your own categorisation system using taxonomy. You can create custom systems of tagging or categorising content, and have single pieces of content belong to multiple categories.

Multiple site setups: a single installation of Drupal can be used to manage multiple web sites.

Inbuilt forum and comment support: while Joomla requires add-ons for these functionalities, Drupal comes with them integrated.

Depending on what suits you best, you can choose either one (or one of the many other CMSs available) and build on it with ready-made or custom extensions. However, if your purpose is to simply have a



Drupal offers a robust front-end to administer its various modules

custom blogging system, or a customised forum, you are better off starting there. Most of the popular blogging platforms that you'll encounter such as Wordpress, or Movable Type are open source, and support their own mechanisms for extensions and themes.

The backend isn't everything. You may need to develop some content that will be for the users' computers, such as Flash content, animations and images.

You will need to create a front-end that users can interact with easily. A fast responsive web site will be useless if it isn't sufficiently engaging. Creating a rich interface with JavaScript and AJAX requires no special tools. However, Flash content can be trickier. You will be pleased to know that an open source solution is available from Adobe!

Adobe offers a full, free and open source Flex SDK which it offers as a programming environment for the development of Flash applications. Unlike Flash, it isn't very intuitive as an animation tool, as it requires everything to be coded. For developing web applications, however, it works.

Creating a unique online experience for your visitor is a tough job indeed, and going for an existing solution makes the job a bit easier. You can continue to customise the web site to your liking

and leave updates to the core functionality and security patches to the developers of the platform. If you feel generous of course you are free to join in and help them out.

API-ing around

Does it seem like too much of a hassle to start your own venture? Then build upon others'. Many major web sites today support a way for users to extend the functionality of the site on their

own. Like a clever buffet system: all the features are laid out for you and all the blame falls on you if you only go for the meat and potatoes.

Orkut, Facebook and MySpace all now allow you to develop applications for their sites.

Orkut runs the open source OpenSocial platform for developing social internet applications. Facebook and MySpace also offer extensive documentation about their APIs, allowing you not only to build applications on their web site, but also to build applications on your own web site which integrate with information from these sites. One can also build desktop applications using information from these sites to make their applications more socially aware.

After learning the basics of their API, you can start developing applications that will run on Orkut, MySpace or Facebook servers. Depending on how useful or fun your application

is, you can become quite a web hero. Considering that some of the popular applications involve throwing toiletries at each other, we think you'll do fine.

Conclusion

Think you're done? Really? What about mail? What about FTP access? Do you really want to send newsletters with attached floppies via the Indian postal system?

When you really develop a web site, it is likely going to evolve as you gain more popularity and resources. It is best to keep that in mind, and make the platform as extendable as possible. You may not need many mail facilities right now, but maybe in the future. You may not need an FTP server to distribute files, but you never know.

You will be pleased to know that there is a plethora of options available in the open source segment for all these needs. In fact, if you have Linux installed, quite a few of these features may already be installed on your system, and the rest will be available on your installation CD. Linux is particularly good for running a server (even while testing) as it is robust and stable and comes with all the server functionality out of the box.

Besides an HTTP server, and a database server, you may additionally need:

- An FTP server: for allowing efficient downloads of files.
- A POP / IMAP and SMTP server: if you need to provide in-house email facility to users of the web site.
- A DNS server: if you want to host the entire server infrastructure on your own terms, you will need your own DNS servers to resolve name requests in your domain.

Some of the greatest and largest web sites have emerged from some of the simplest ideas, whether it's merely posting what you're doing right now or making long URLs shorter. Go ahead, hitch your wagon to the stars, who knows your web site may someday become the best for remote encoding of media files for parallel distribution via multiple channels. 

